PROJECT REPORT: DIGITAL LITERACY AND PROFESSIONAL PRESENCE

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1. Introduction

The objective of this project was to develop a comprehensive understanding of digital literacy, covering creative design, professional networking, cybersecurity awareness, and effective digital communication. In an increasingly digital academic and professional landscape, these foundational skills are essential for both long-term career growth and personal safety online.

2. Task-Wise Project Execution

2.1 Task 1: Digital Design & Creativity

For the first task of this project, the primary objective was to explore and demonstrate digital design and creativity by developing a structured presentation template. Utilizing Canva, a prominent cloud-based design platform, I created a comprehensive template specifically tailored for presenting digital literacy concepts. This exercise was not merely about aesthetic appeal but focused heavily on visual communication principles. I learned how to effectively organize information using visual hierarchies, select appropriate color schemes, and utilize typography to make complex digital concepts easily digestible for a general audience. The process emphasized the importance of maintaining a consistent and professional design language, which is a critical skill for modern academic and corporate environments. By building this template from scratch, I developed a hands-on understanding of how digital tools can be leveraged to enhance storytelling and knowledge sharing. The final deliverable serves as a reusable asset that perfectly balances creative design with the functional requirement of educating others about fundamental digital literacy skills. This task ultimately proved that effective communication today relies heavily on visual digital competence and the ability to present information clearly.

2.2 Task 2: Professional Profile Building

Task 2 focused on establishing a robust and professional digital footprint across key industry-standard platforms. Recognizing that a strong online presence is crucial for career advancement, I systematically curated profiles on LinkedIn, GitHub, and Kaggle. On LinkedIn, I built a comprehensive profile detailing my academic trajectory as a first-year student in the Integrated M.Tech Computational and Data Science program at VIT Bhopal University. I optimized it to connect with industry professionals and track upcoming internship opportunities. For software development and version control, I set up a GitHub repository. This serves as a practical portfolio to host my coding projects, demonstrating my ability to manage code and collaborate effectively with other developers. Furthermore, to explicitly align with my specific field of study, I created a profile on Kaggle, a premier platform for data science and machine learning. Engaging with Kaggle allows me to access real-world datasets, participate in community discussions, and showcase my analytical capabilities. Together, these three platforms form a highly cohesive professional identity, ensuring that recruiters find a verified, consistent, and well-rounded representation of my skills.

2.3 Task 3: Problem Solving & Peer Engagement

This task was divided into two distinct components: technical problem-solving and community engagement. First, I utilized the HackerRank platform to hone my algorithmic thinking and coding proficiency. I successfully solved the "Sum of Numbers" challenge using Python, demonstrating my ability to apply fundamental programming logic to structural computational problems. This highlights the foundational technical skills required in modern digital environments. The second component involved designing and deploying a 'Digital Literacy Awareness Quiz' using Google Workspace tools. I created a structured, five-question interactive form targeting my batchmates to assess their understanding of critical topics like password management, identifying phishing attempts, and maintaining proper netiquette. After distributing the quiz to my peers, I collected and documented the responses in a structured PDF format. This exercise was highly insightful, as it not only tested my ability to use collaborative digital tools to gather and analyze data, but it also provided a clear snapshot of the current digital awareness levels among my peers. It emphasized that true digital literacy involves both the technical capacity to write functional code and the social capacity to educate others.

2.4 Task 4: Professional Communication & Etiquette

Task 4 centered on the nuances of professional digital communication and the ethical responsibilities of maintaining an online presence. I began by drafting two formal emails: one requesting an assignment extension from a professor due to unforeseen medical circumstances, and another inquiring about summer internship opportunities at Google

India. These drafts allowed me to practice essential professional writing skills, focusing strictly on clarity, maintaining a respectful tone, and using concise formatting. Additionally, I compiled a comprehensive 'Do's and Don'ts' checklist for social media usage to guide responsible online behavior. To underscore the real-world implications of digital etiquette, I analyzed a compelling 2023 case study. The scenario involved a college student who posted a casual, frustrated complaint about a faculty member's teaching style on a public Instagram story. The post quickly went viral within the college community, resulting in a formal complaint being raised against the student and permanently damaging their academic relationship. This case study served as a stark reminder of digital permanence, reinforcing that professional communication extends across all social media networks.

2.5 Task 5: Cybercrime Awareness & Prevention

The final task addressed the critical issue of cybersecurity through an in-depth analysis of financial fraud. I examined a prevalent case study involving a second-year engineering college student in Pune who fell victim to a UPI-based cybercrime. The student received a deceptive WhatsApp message from scammers posing as a 'Scholarship Cell,' claiming an Rs. 8,000 grant was approved. Exploiting a common gap in digital literacy, the fraudsters convinced the excited student to scan a QR code via Google Pay to 'receive' the funds. Instead, the money was immediately debited from their account. This highlighted a vital concept: in the UPI framework, scanning a QR code is exclusively an action for sending money, never for receiving it. To combat such widespread threats, I developed an 8-point prevention checklist focusing on actionable safety measures, such as implementing Two-Factor Authentication (2FA), avoiding suspicious links, and never sharing UPI PINs. Furthermore, the task emphasized the critical importance of rapid incident response, outlining essential reporting channels like the National Cyber Crime Portal (cybercrime.gov.in) and the 1930 emergency helpline to improve recovery chances.

3. Reflection and Conclusion

Through this project, I realized that digital literacy is not just about technical skills but also about "social engineering" awareness. Fraudsters often exploit trust, urgency, and a lack of awareness rather than utilizing advanced technical hacking skills. The QR code confusion is a prime example of an effective trap that exploits a genuine gap in digital literacy. This project has equipped me with the essential tools to actively manage

my professional identity while staying secure and vigilant in an increasingly complex digital world.

4. Digital Project Links

● **GitHub Repository:** Digital-litracy

● **Canva Design:** Template Link

● **Awareness Quiz:**
https://docs.google.com/forms/d/e/1FAIpQLScnh7H8bCHAU-RAn-nqDgX-c6SeNQ_1lWr6Htjm7UYHVtuBDA/viewform?usp=header●

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